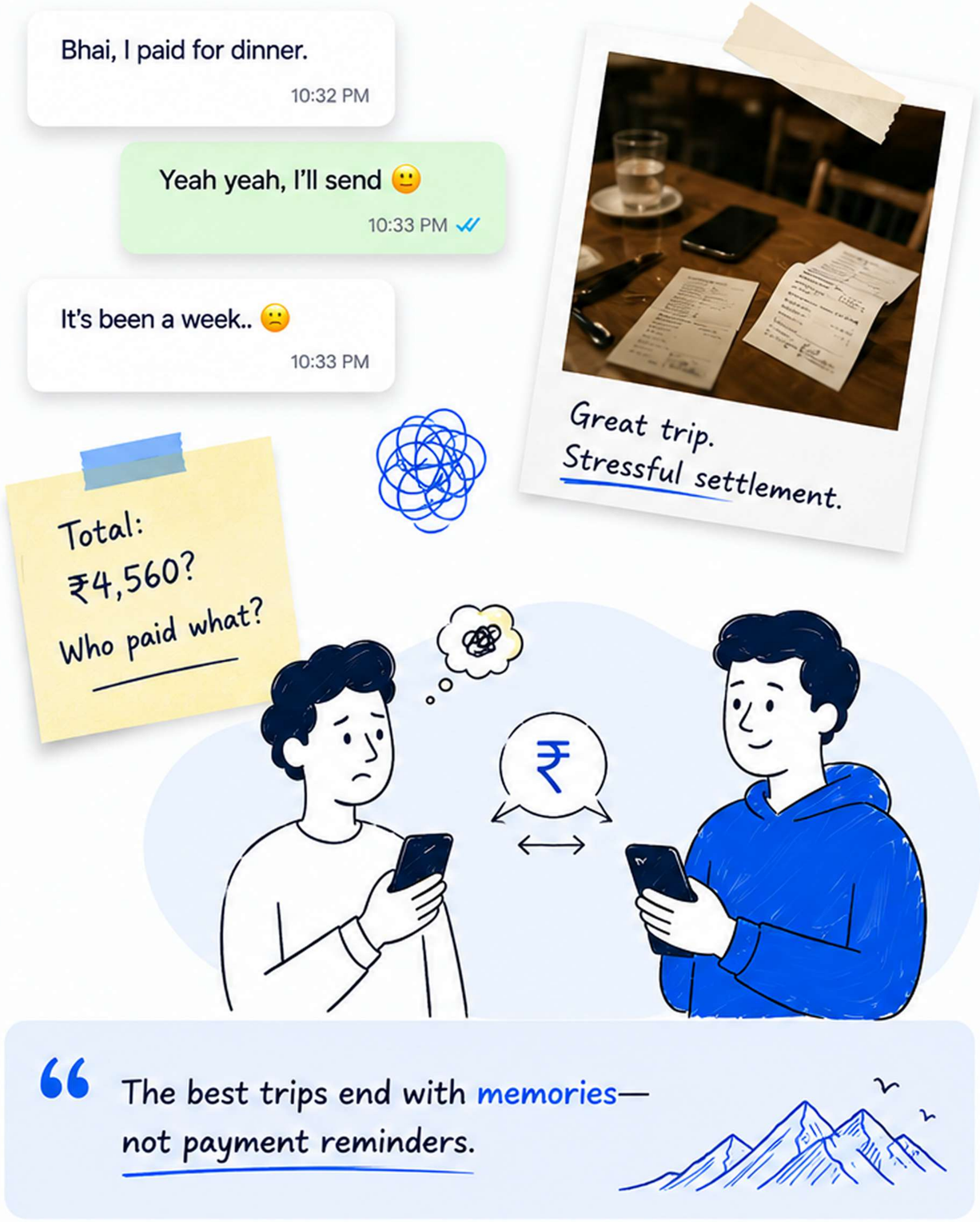
What if you never had to ask a friend to pay you back?

A design exploration into the hidden anxiety of shared expenses and why tracking was never the real problem.

Conceptual design

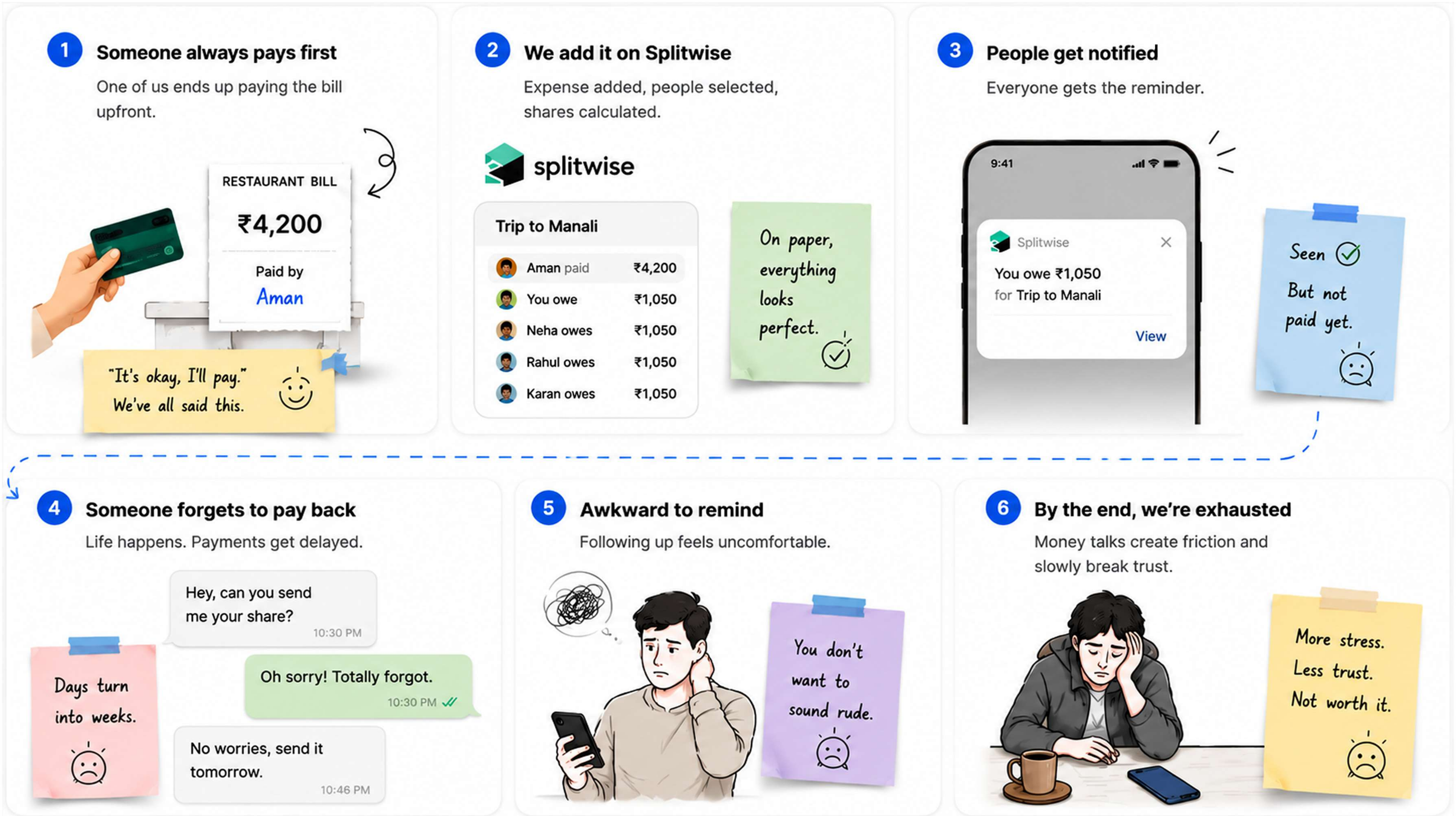
5min read



The trip ended. The stress didn't

A few months ago, while planning a trip with friends, I noticed that **managing shared expenses** was more stressful than the trip itself.

Someone always pays first, someone forgets to pay back, reminding feels awkward-and by the end, we lose track, lose trust, and feel exhausted.



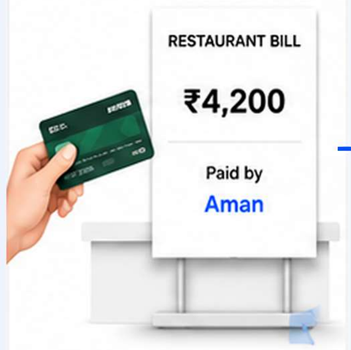
Can this experience be redesigned?

The Existing Experience

Splitwise

Today, we rely on apps like Splitwise to manage shared expenses.

1 Friend pays the bill



One person pays the full amount upfront.

No worries, I'll pay today.

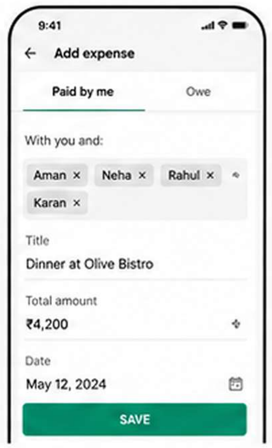
2 Open Splitwise



They open the app to add the expense.

Extra step right after paying.

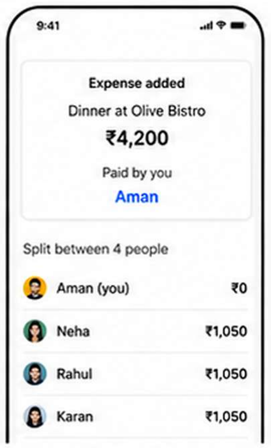
3 Add expense manually



Enter amount, select friends, choose category, date, etc.

Manual work when you just want to relax.

4 Everyone gets added



Splitwise calculates and shows who owes how much.

Looks organized, but story just begins.

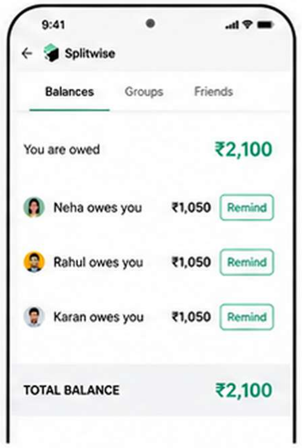
5 Reminders & follow-ups



You wait, remind, follow up. Sometimes multiple times.

Awkward to remind friends.

6 Wait for repayment



You're still waiting for money to come back.

Until paid, it sits in your head.

Research & Observations

I wanted to know if others felt this too. So I spoke with friends, roommates, and frequent travelers

User Interviews
8 conversations

- Friends & classmates
- Roommates
- Frequent travelers

What people told us

I hate opening Splitwise after every payment.

I only remember to add expenses after a long time.

I don't trust everyone to pay me back on time.

I feel awkward asking friends for money.

Nobody remembers who paid what.

We end up using WhatsApp, UPI and Splitwise together.

Tracking every chai, cab and snack is just too much work.

If someone forgets to add an expense, the final calculation is wrong.

The reminders work, but they don't make people pay.

Manual entry becomes exhausting during long trips.

Everyone says 'I'll send it later'... but later never comes.

I know how much I'm owed. The problem is getting it back.

Raw observations, no conclusions drawn yet.

From these conversations, four patterns kept coming up.

1 Manual tracking is exhausting

Observation
Users dislike logging every payment manually.

Design Direction
Automate expense tracking.

2 Repayments depend on trust

Observation
Knowing who owes money isn't the problem. Getting the money back is.

Design Direction
Reduce dependency on repayments.

3 Too many apps create friction

Observation
Users constantly switch between UPI apps, WhatsApp and Splitwise.

Design Direction
Keep the experience in one place.

4 Money conversations feel awkward

Observation
Repeated reminders make friendships uncomfortable.

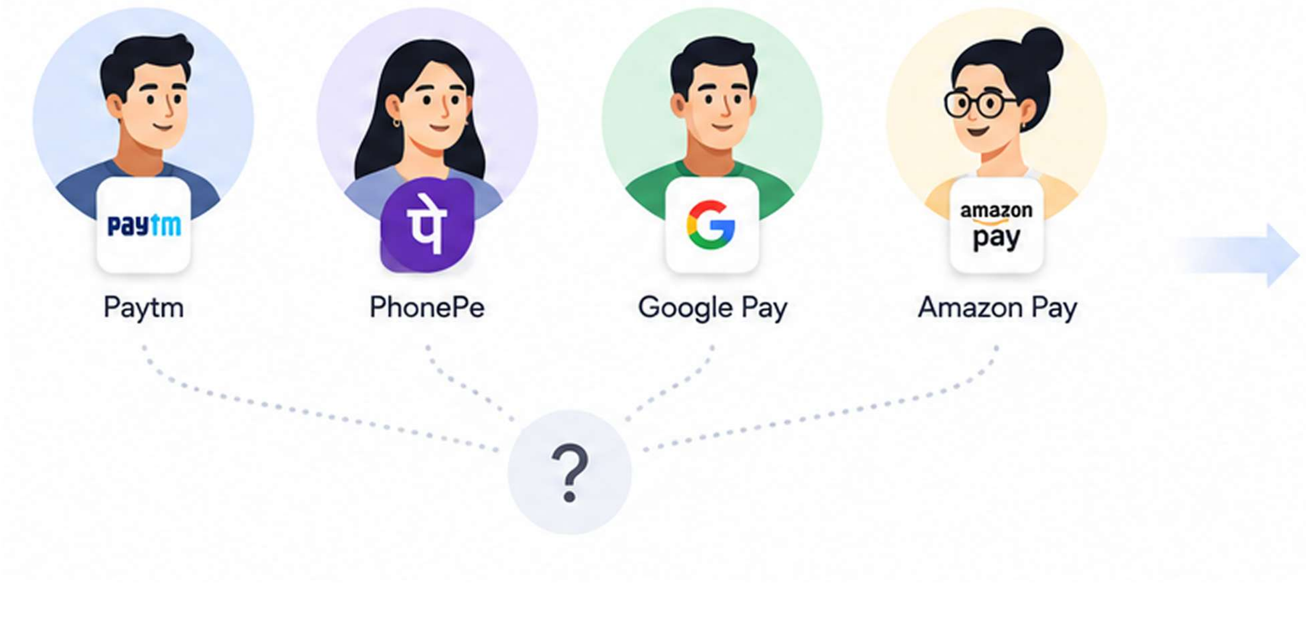
Design Direction
Minimize manual follow-ups.

This became our checklist for evaluating every idea.

- [x] Does it reduce manual tracking?
- [x] Does it reduce repayment dependency?
- [x] Does it avoid app switching?
- [x] Does it reduce awkward money conversations?

Our design constraint.

while testing the concept, we identified an important limitation.
What happens when group members use different UPI apps?



Concept Assumption

To evaluate the experience itself, we assumed all participants were using Paytm.

This allowed us to validate the contribute-first model without introducing cross-platform constraints.

Future opportunities this opens up

Cross-platform wallet

Enable groups to include members using any UPI app.

Standalone group payment app

A dedicated app built exclusively for group payments.

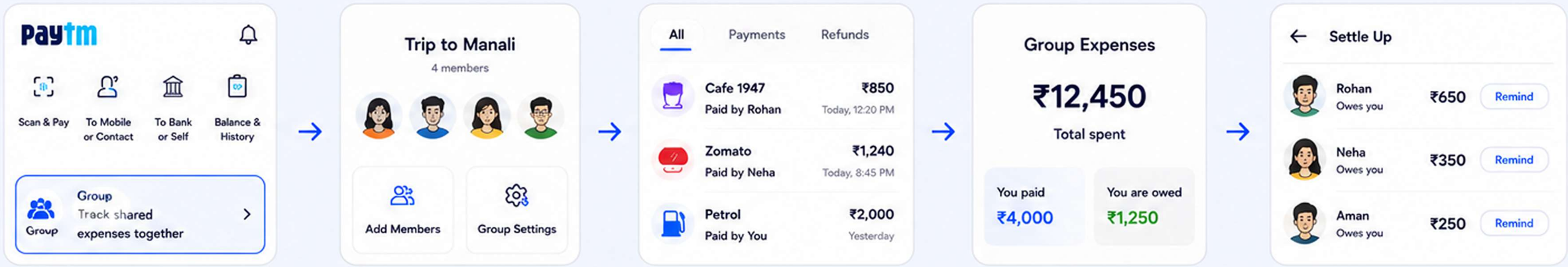
Universal shared UPI infrastructure

Build a neutral layer that powers group payments across all apps.

"The goal of this project wasn't to solve interoperability.
It was to validate whether pre-funded group payments reduce repayment anxiety."

Our First Approach

We explored creating groups inside Paytm so that all payments made by group members are automatically tracked.



1 Create Group
Start a group with friends or family.

2 Invite Members
Add people who are part of the group.

3 Everyone Pays
Make payments as usual from inside the group.

4 Auto Tracking
All expenses are recorded and split automatically.

5 Send Reminders
Paytm calculates who owes whom and sends reminders.

What this solved

No more manual tracking	Expenses are captured automatically inside Paytm.
Everything in one place	No need to switch between UPI apps, WhatsApp and Splitwise.
Better visibility	All group expenses and history are available to everyone.
Transparent calculations	Paytm shows who paid, who owes and the exact amounts.

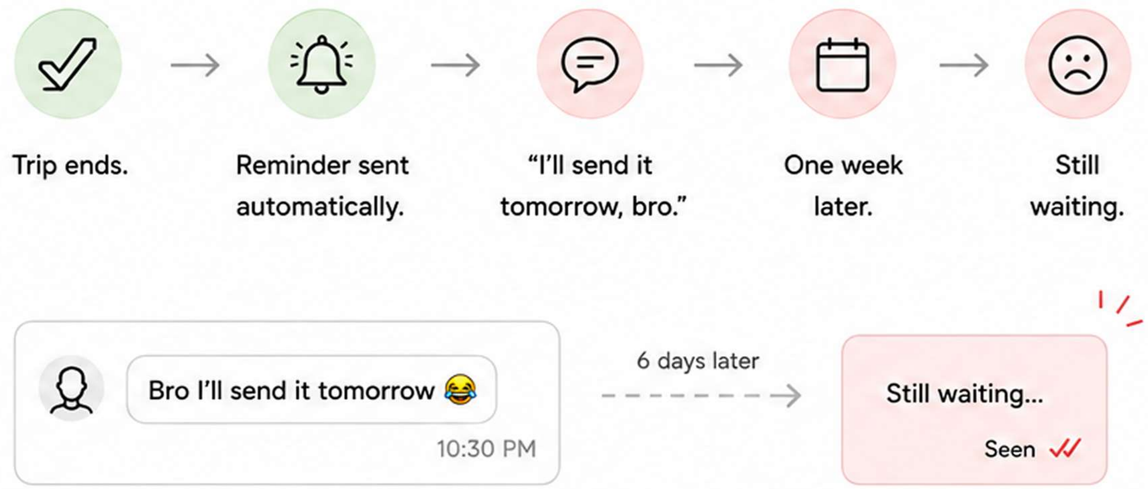
What it didn't solve

Repayments still required	People still need to settle balances later.
Depends on trust	Reminders don't guarantee payment.
Reminders are not enough	People can still ignore or delay.
Awkward conversations continue	Asking for money can still feel uncomfortable.

This approach removed the pain of manual tracking, but the bigger problem of getting the money back remained. ⇢ **We needed to rethink the problem**

Then I realized something.

The real problem wasn't
tracking expenses.
It was getting the money back.



No matter how good the tracking is,
repayment still depends on human behaviour.

And humans — even good ones —
delay, forget, and avoid.

So I asked a different question.

↓

I needed a better way —
a way where **nobody has to pay back anyone.**

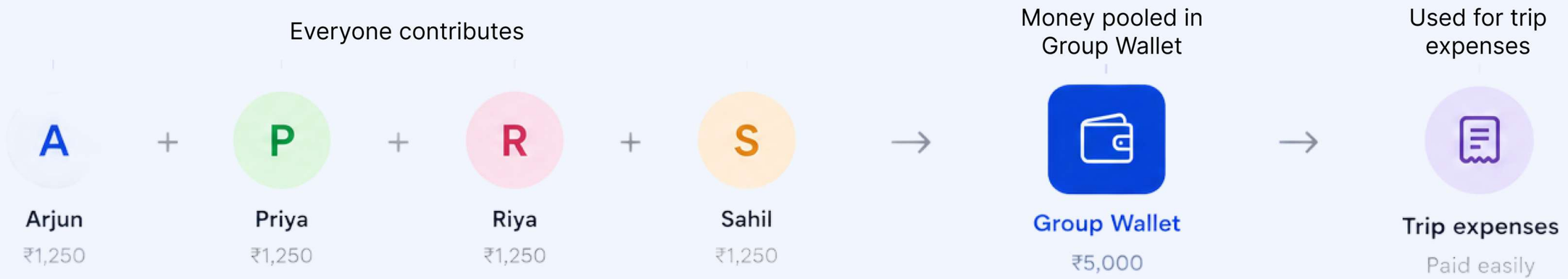
What If nobody had to pay later?

Instead of setting after spending what if
everyone contributed before?

Contribute first. Spend together. Get the rest back automatically.

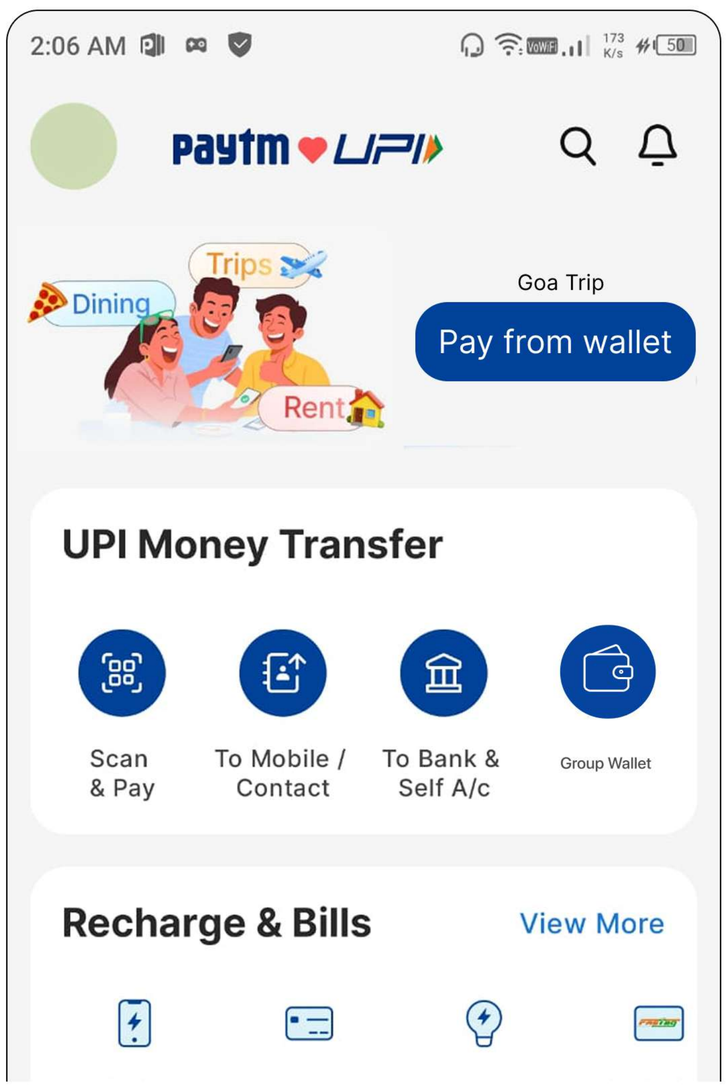
This removes the entire repayment dependency.there's no "I'll send tomorrow."

The money is already in the wallet before anyone spends it.



Introducing Group Wallet

Here's how the experience actually works each screen answers one question in the user's journey.

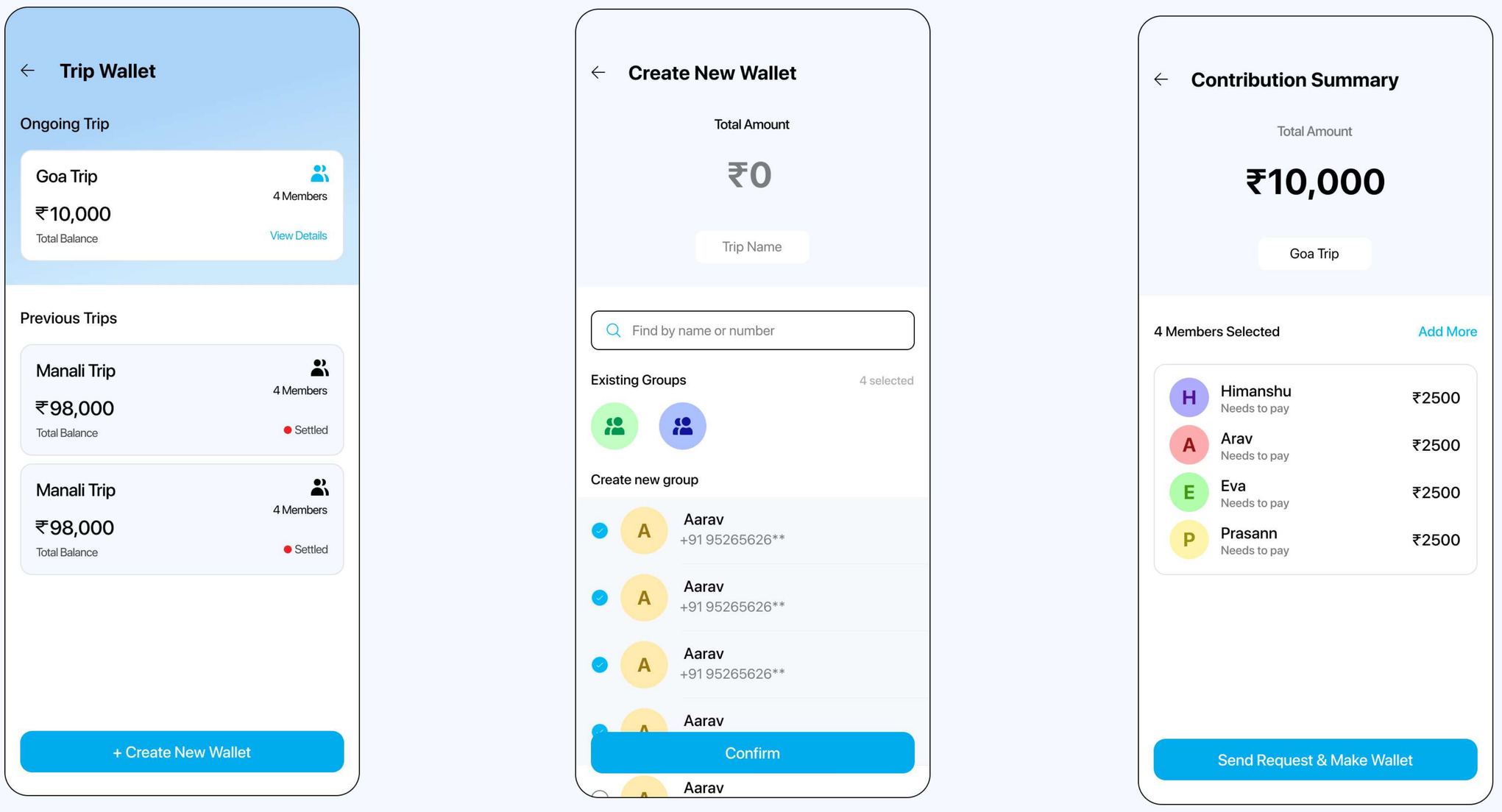


Where does it live in the app?

When a trip is active, a contextual banner appears on the Paytm home screen. The user can pay directly without navigating anywhere.

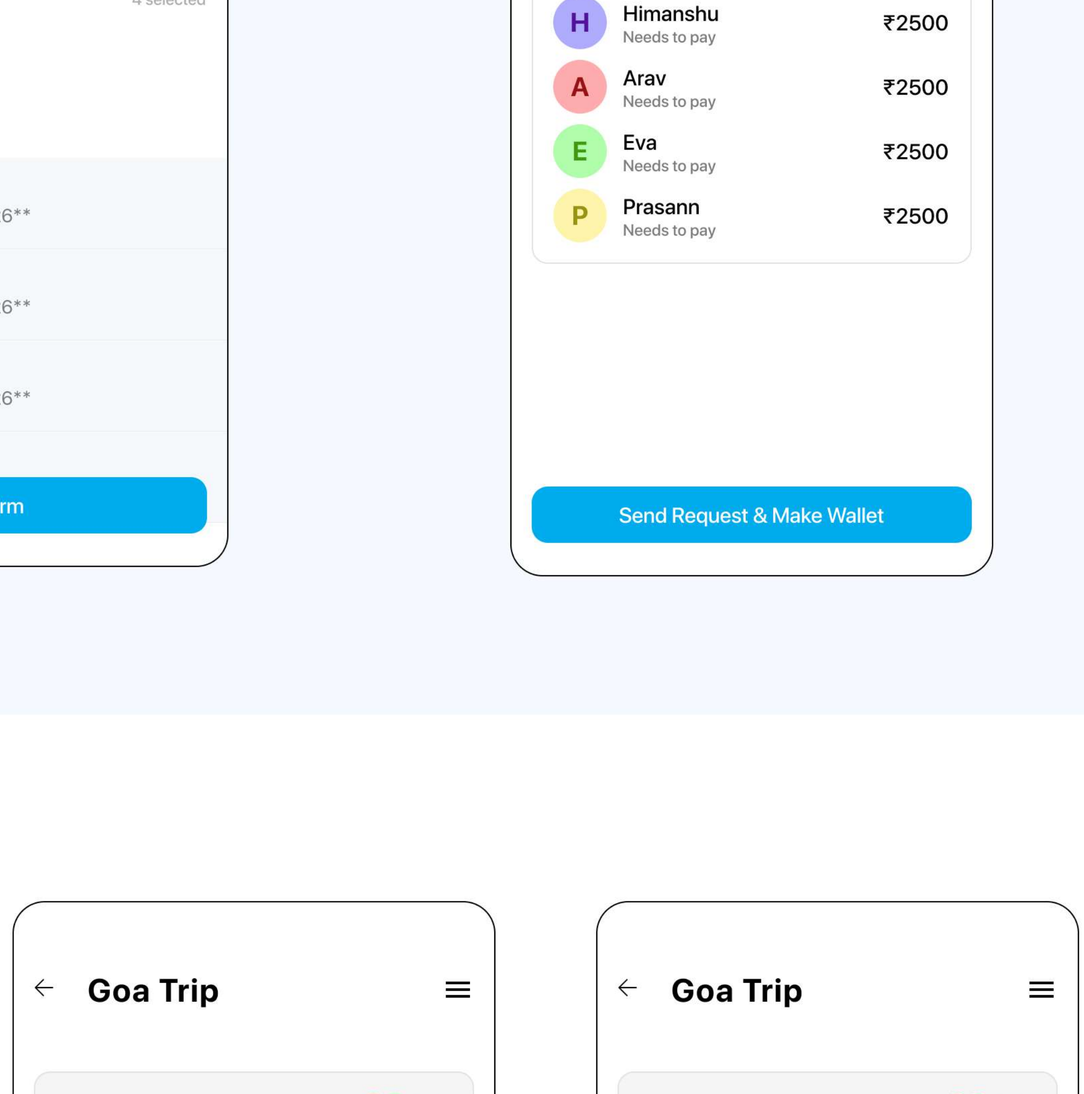
How does someone start a group wallet?

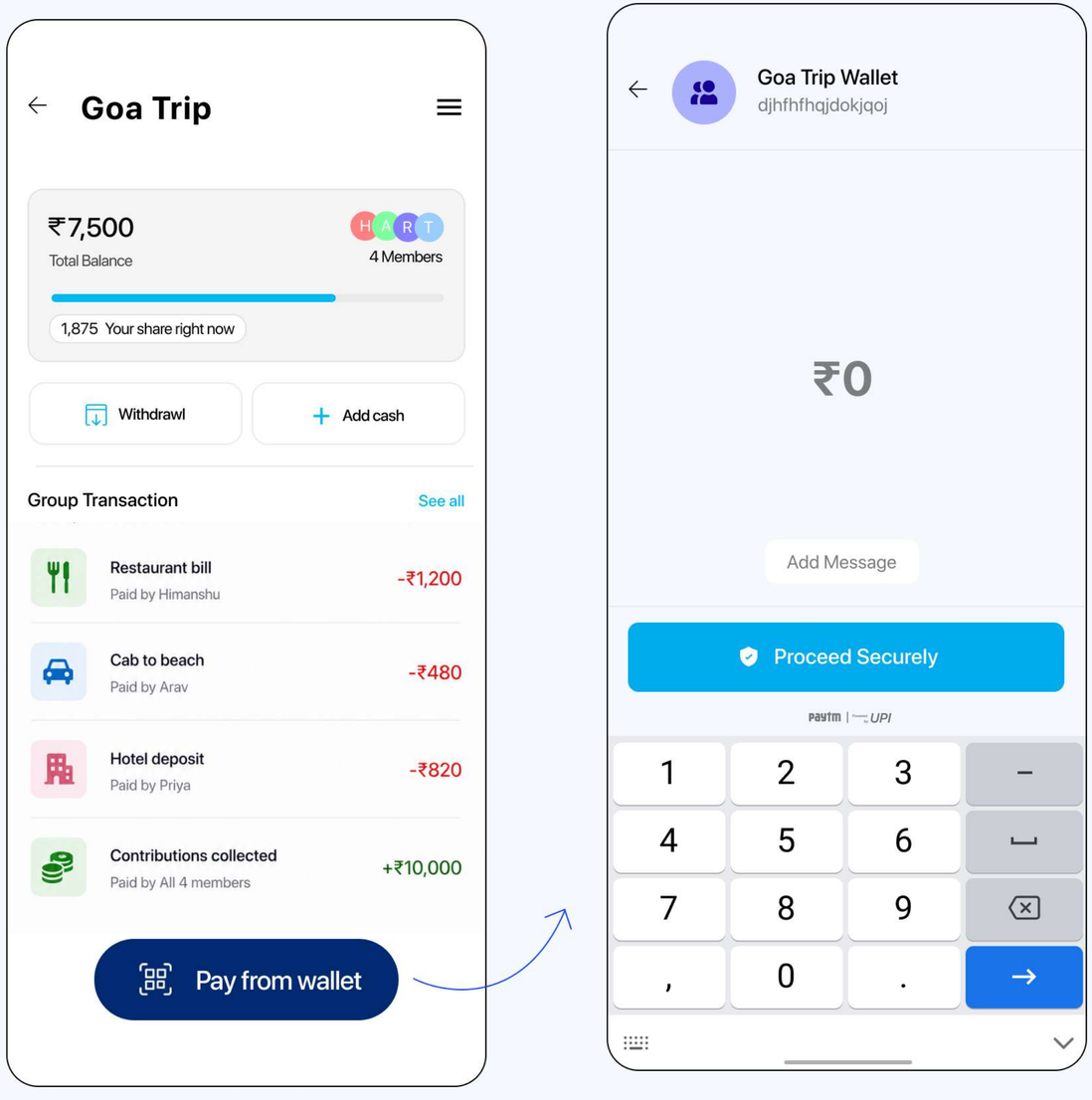
Trip name, total amount, select members three steps, one screen. The wallet is created the moment everyone is selected.



How does everyone pay in before the trip?

Each member sees exactly what they owe. One tap to contribute. The wallet only activates once all contributions are received.



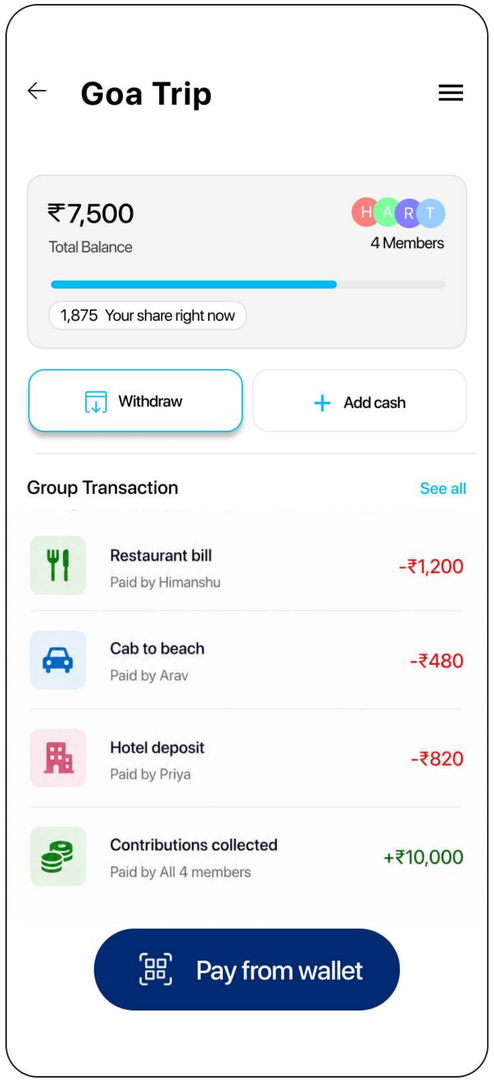


What does the main experience look like during the trip?

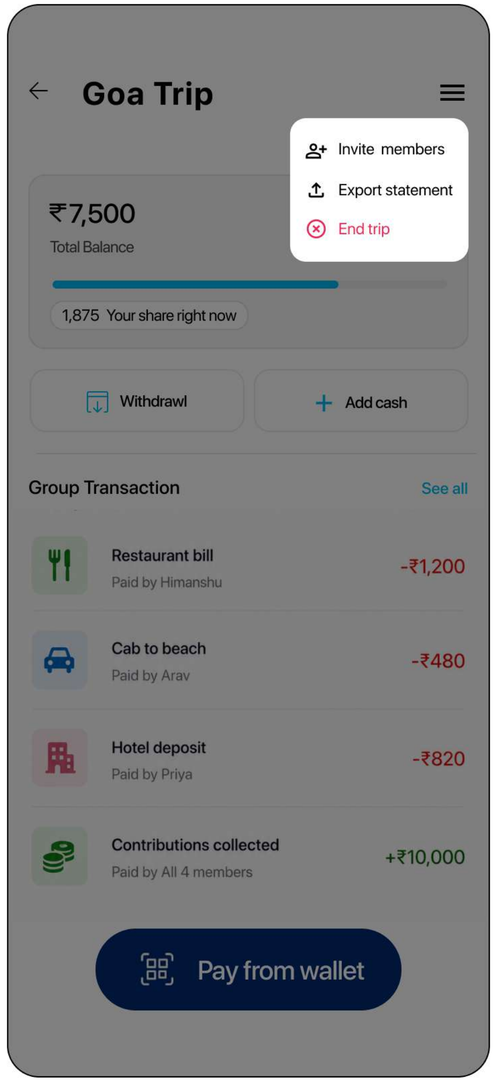
Balance, your personal share, spending progress, and group transactions — all on one screen. One primary action: Pay from wallet.

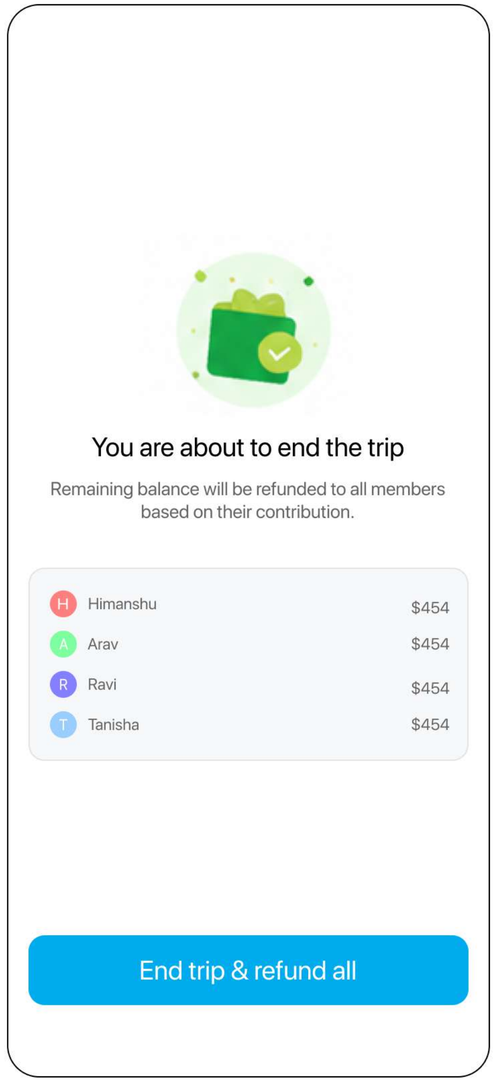
How does the trip close?

members can withdraw their share at any time



Admin can end the trip





Every member gets their share refunded automatically to their Paytm wallet. No follow-up needed. No awkward messages. The system handled it.